Getting in on THE ACT

One of Bollywood's most sought-after actresses in the 1990s, **Juhi Chawla** has finally taken the OTT plunge with the Amazon Prime Rishi Kapoor-starrer *Sharmaji Namkeen*

Q. While many of your peers have forayed into streaming, *Sharmaji Namkeen* is your first direct-to-digital release. What do you seek from a project?

The script has to be compelling and it has to be a story I would like to be a part of and watch. Once you hear it, your decision should be spontaneous. OTT or theatrical release is not the criteria.

Q. This is Rishi Kapoor's last film. What was it like collaborating with him after almost two decades?

Chintuji [Rishi Kapoor] was Chintuji. I had observed him for 25 years and he hadn't changed. He would scold someone, wind someone up or make fun of somebody on set. He would say to me, '*Kya lipstick phir se laga rahi hai* [Why are you putting on lipstick again?'] Why do you keep going to see the monitor? Why are you so insecure?' I'd laugh at his comments.

Q. *Sharmaji Namkeen* saw Paresh Rawal filling in for Rishi Kapoor after his demise. It's a unique experiment...

We began shooting and then Chintuji had to undergo treatment. We took a break and resumed shooting after he was fine, but then the lockdown started. A month later, he was no more. It was a big shock to all of us. He had wrapped 50 per cent of the film. I appreciated the producer's gesture, ensuring that a great actor's last work wouldn't be locked up but be shared with audiences. I was ready to shoot whenever they wanted.

Q. We don't see many actresses doing comedy of the sort you did in the 1990s...

It was the time, the set-up, the directors, the co-stars...there was a lot more innocence and madness. *Masti masti mein karte the* [we would have a lot of fun at work]. I was hugely inspired by Sridevi. When she would come on screen, she could light up a comedy scene, a romantic or seductive scene, or even a dramatic one. She was my idol. Padmini Kolhapure, Mumtaz, Rekha...I was trying to be a fraction of all of them.

–with Suhani Singh



AFP